

**POLL RHYTHM** CM Shivraj Singh Chouhan beats the drum with tribal artists in Bhopal

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2003, also avoided it.

The Rules under the PESA empower the gram sabhas on issues of minor forest produce collection and dispute-resolution in mining and excise, which were contested by the departments concerned at the deliberation stage. Chief Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan, while speaking at Shahdol, made it a point to mention that the PESA Rules were not aimed at alienating anyone but to empower tribals—evidence that he was aware of the tightrope walk involved in the notifying process. "The implementation of the PESA Act will give tribals power over their land, water and forests. This is a revolutionary step and I'm happy it is being announced on the birth anniversary of Birsa Munda," Chouhan said.

With an eye on tribal support, the BJP has announced a slew of other measures too. Recruitment has been initiated to fill up vacancies reserved for tribals in all government departments; special programmes for tackling health issues, specifically among tribals, have been launched; and illegal money-lending is to be checked. In addition, tribal heroes are being discovered and celebrated, and their histories are being brought to the fore. A renaming spree has had many old and new government facilities being named after tribal icons. Those figures who had a dispute with a Muslim ruler and resisted missionaries or western influence are specifically being honoured through various means.

The pro-tribal mood is also evident in the day-to-day administration of the state. An incident of atrocity against tribals is taken seriously and accountability is fixed, often resulting in the transfer of the official under whose jurisdiction the lapse occurred. Despite all these measures, MP has a high incidence of crimes against tribals. According to the latest data with the National Crime Records Bureau, with 2,627 cases of crime against STs in 2021, the state tops the list in India—a record it held in 2020 and 2019 as well. Besides this, malnutrition, a problem that the state has been grappling with for long, is prevalent to a greater degree among tribals. As per the National Family Health Survey 5, among all marginalised communities (SC, ST and OBC), the incidence of severe stunting and severe wasting is highest among tribals at 17.7 per cent and 13.9 per cent, respectively.

The Congress is underwhelmed by Chouhan's outreach. "The formulation of PESA Rules has been done hurriedly with an eye on the 2023 assembly election. Since the BJP has been in power in MP since 2003, it also needs to answer what took it 18 years," says Congress spokesperson K.K. Mishra. "The day the President was in MP, 70 tribals were agitating in Satna to get compensation for their land. Formulating Rules is one thing, what is missing is the intention to implement it," he adds. Aware that the PESA Act may just remain a legislative exercise and not yield political dividends unless explained to people, the state BJP has decided to take out a PESA Jagrukta Yatra (PESA Awareness Yatra) from November 20 that will cover all 89 tribal development blocks in the state and end on December 4. We will have to wait till 2023, though, to see how it translates into votes. ■